

Half Marathon Training Plan

12-Week Beginner Program

Race Distance: 21.1 kilometers (13.1 miles)

Target Audience: Runners with 5K experience or basic running fitness

Prerequisites: Able to run 5K continuously or have completed 5K training program

Weekly Training: 4-5 days per week | 4-6 hours total

Program Structure: 3 cycles with progressive long runs and speed work

Program Overview

This 12-week program takes runners from 5K fitness to half marathon ready. The plan introduces long runs, tempo runs, and speed work to build endurance and race-specific fitness. By race day, you'll have completed a 20K long run and be confident crossing the finish line.

Key Principles:

- Progressive long run increases (no more than 10% per week)
 - One speed/tempo session per week for race pace development
 - One easy run and one moderate run per week
 - Strategic taper in final weeks
 - Injury prevention through proper recovery and cross-training
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CYCLE 1: BASE BUILDING (Weeks 1-4)

Week 1: Introduction to Half Marathon Training

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Tempo Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 20 min at tempo pace (comfortably hard)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 40 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

Week 2: Build Tempo Work

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Tempo Run (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 25 min at tempo pace
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (50 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 45 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3.5 hours

Week 3: Increase Long Run

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Tempo Run (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 25 min at tempo pace
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (55 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk

- Main Set: 50 min easy running (approximately 8K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3.5 hours

Week 4: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 40 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2.5 hours

CYCLE 2: BUILDING ENDURANCE (Weeks 5-8)

Week 5: Extended Tempo Work

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Tempo Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 30 min at tempo pace
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (60 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 55 min easy running (approximately 9K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4 hours

Week 6: Speed Work Introduction

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk

- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Speed Work (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 6 x 800m at race pace with 2 min recovery jog between
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (65 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 60 min easy running (approximately 10K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4 hours

Week 7: Build Long Run

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Speed Work (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 8 x 800m at race pace with 2 min recovery jog
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (70 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 65 min easy running (approximately 11K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

Week 8: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (55 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 50 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

CYCLE 3: RACE PREPARATION (Weeks 9-12)

Week 9: Peak Long Run

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Speed Work (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 10 x 800m at race pace with 2 min recovery jog
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (80 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 75 min easy running (approximately 12.5K distance)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

Week 10: Maximum Long Run

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 30 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Tempo Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 30 min at tempo pace
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (90 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 80 min easy running (approximately 13.5K distance - over half marathon distance!)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

Week 11: Begin Taper

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 25 min easy running

- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Tempo Run (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk + 5 min easy jog
- Main Set: 25 min at tempo pace
- Cool-down: 5 min easy jog + 5 min easy walk

Thursday: Rest day

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Long Run (70 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 65 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~3.5 hours

Week 12: RACE WEEK

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Run (20 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 15 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Run (15 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy walk
- Main Set: 10 min easy running
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Rest day - Final preparations

- Lay out all gear
- Review race course
- Early bed time

Sunday: RACE DAY!

- Arrive 45 min early
- Warm up gently with 10 min walk + 10 min easy jog
- Trust your 12 weeks of training
- Have fun and enjoy the experience!

Weekly Volume: ~1 hour

Running Pacing Guidelines

Easy Pace: You should be able to hold a conversation comfortably. This is your primary training pace.

Tempo Pace: Comfortably hard. You can speak a few words but not full sentences. Approximately 25-30 seconds per mile slower than race pace.

Race Pace: The pace you plan to run the half marathon. You can speak in short sentences but not full conversations.

Speed Work Pace: 800m repeats should be at approximately 5K race pace or slightly faster.

Nutrition for Half Marathon Training

Pre-Run (1-2 hours before):

- Banana with almond butter

- Toast with jam
- Rice cakes with honey
- Small bowl of oatmeal

During Run (sessions >60 min):

- Water with electrolytes every 15-20 min
- Sports drink or energy gels every 30-45 min
- Aim for 30-60g carbs per hour

Post-Run (within 30 min):

- Protein + carbs (chicken with rice, protein smoothie, turkey sandwich)
 - Rehydrate with water or electrolyte drink
 - Aim for 3:1 carb to protein ratio
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Injury Prevention

Warm-up: Always start with 5 minutes of easy walking before running.

Cool-down: Always end with 5 minutes of easy walking after running.

Stretching: Stretch for 15-20 minutes after each run, focusing on calves, hamstrings, quads, hip flexors, and IT band.

Cross-Training: Consider one day of cross-training (cycling, swimming, strength training) per week for injury prevention.

Rest Days: Take at least 2-3 complete rest days per week. Your body adapts during rest, not during training.

Listen to Your Body: If you experience sharp pain (not just muscle soreness), take an extra rest day or consult a healthcare provider.

Race Week Checklist

- ☐ Lay out all gear the night before
- ☐ Check weather forecast
- ☐ Review race course map and elevation profile
- ☐ Plan parking and arrival time
- ☐ Practice race-day breakfast
- ☐ Get good sleep 2-3 nights before
- ☐ Reduce training volume by 80%
- ☐ Eat familiar foods only
- ☐ Hydrate consistently
- ☐ Arrive 45 minutes early on race day
- ☐ Plan fueling strategy during race

Remember: This is YOUR training plan. Adjust rest days as needed to fit your life. Consistency beats perfection. You've got this! 🏃